

KEY FORCE

KNIGHTS TEMPLAR
1119–1312

Founded in Jerusalem during the Crusades, the Knights Templar were a military organization dedicated to the defence of Christianity. While following religious rules of conduct, the Templars were also elite fighters in the Crusader wars against Muslim forces. They took part in the failed defence of the last of the Crusader kingdoms in 1291, after which they were suppressed by the papacy and their wealth plundered by King Philip IV of France.



▲ A knight charges with his lance at the ready. The cross on his shield identifies him as a crusader.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

ARMoured CAVALRY
IN MEDIEVAL EUROPE

The armoured knight appeared as the key figure in western European warfare around the 11th–12th centuries. The armour and weaponry of this elite warrior evolved constantly in search of better protection and more effective attack.

Heavily armoured cavalry first developed in Asia, and reached Europe through the Roman Empire's contacts with Sassanid Persia from the 3rd century CE. As a result, the Byzantine Empire fielded cataphracts (early heavy cavalry) as its shock battlefield force. Both the cataphract and his horse were fully covered by scale armour, which was made of overlapping metal plates. His main weapon was a long lance. Sustaining such a warrior required a supply of purpose-bred large horses, skilled metalworkers, and the resources to pay for these.

DEVELOPMENTS IN ARMOUR

Cavalry in western Europe evolved independently, but was influenced by the Byzantine example. Mounted forces had adopted the lance by the 12th century, but their armour was still relatively primitive. A coat of mail, the hauberk, covered the body, while the head was protected by a mail hood and conical iron helm, the face exposed except for a "nasal", a central metal guard covering the nose. The cylindrical great helm completely enclosed the heads of the knights who fought for Richard the Lionheart on the Third Crusade in 1191–92, improving protection but sacrificing all-round vision and ease of breathing. Over the years, plate armour was added, first on the legs, arms, and shoulders. The great helm was superseded by the pointed basinet with a hinged visor.

By the 15th century, suits of full plate armour had come into general use. A well-made suit of armour, its weight well distributed, never

prevented a knight mounting his horse unaided or fighting on foot: its main disadvantage was that it caused overheating. Both armour and helmets continued to evolve in terms of the skill of manufacture and complexity of design and decoration, reaching a pinnacle of elaboration in the 16th century, by which time display was as important a function as practical defence.

KNIGHTS IN COMBAT

The evolution of armour also led to changes in weaponry. The ideal knightly combat – rarely encountered outside jousting tournaments – started with a charge with couched lance (held in the attacking position), followed by a close-quarters mêlée. In the era of mail, knights hacked



◀ WAR-HAMMER

The short-handled war-hammer was a weapon used by late medieval knights. The hammer could deliver a stunning blow to a helmet, while the spike might penetrate weak points in armour.

